continued through a quick breakfast stop (where he ate toast and omelette with his hands). It was possible to challenge him and disagree with him in a way you can't with most Indian politicians—certainly not with Prime Minister Modi, who refuses to engage even in press conferences. Instead, Indian citizens are given the shock-and-awe strategy of lavish stage-managed events, multiple camera angles covering every move of Modi and his perfect grooming, with all others, even foreign dignitaries, pushed aside so as not to distract attention from him.[4] In contrast, the sight of Rahul Gandhi, in an unkempt beard and trainers, walking along, surrounded by ordinary people is a compelling one.

During the hour or so I spent with him, he invited in young men, schoolgirls and an elderly farmer carrying a container of wheat on his head, engaging each in conversation about their work, asking after an injury he might have spotted on their arm or face or just holding their hand and walking. His team held up a QR code for those who wanted their picture with Rahul, so they could download them from the BJY website by the end of the day. Every inch of the route, cries of 'Love you, Rahul!' and 'Rahul Gandhi Zindabad' could be heard. A young schoolgirl he invited in could barely contain her excitement as he engaged her in conversation about the card she clutched. It was the Preamble to India's Constitution, and he asked her to read it aloud and discussed the meaning of words such as 'justice' and 'fraternity', before making sure she was safely reunited with her father. It is this easy unpretentiousness, genuine curiosity about people and decency that people notice and talk about once the procession has passed.

It is true, however, that the Congress party's failure in recent years to win enough elections is also blamed on Rahul. Certainly, the party organization has been moribund and party workers have been fractious and demoralized. But the Yatra has gone some way in galvanizing those troops, who have rallied around to put on this enormous roadshow, organizing the logistics of food, shelter and toilets on a daily basis, mile after mile, across several months. Whether the Yatra marks a change in the Congress's electoral fortunes remains to be seen, but it has given back to many Indians